

Mediterranean gardens

There are two types of gardens associated with the Mediterranean region: formal and informal. The formal gardens feature water and stone, as well as clipped hedges and specimen trees such as pencil cypresses. Decorative parterres are also common, with the plants selected for foliage rather than flower color. In some gardens in Spain, such as the El Alhambra in Granada, there is a strong Moorish influence, with formal courtyards and water features.

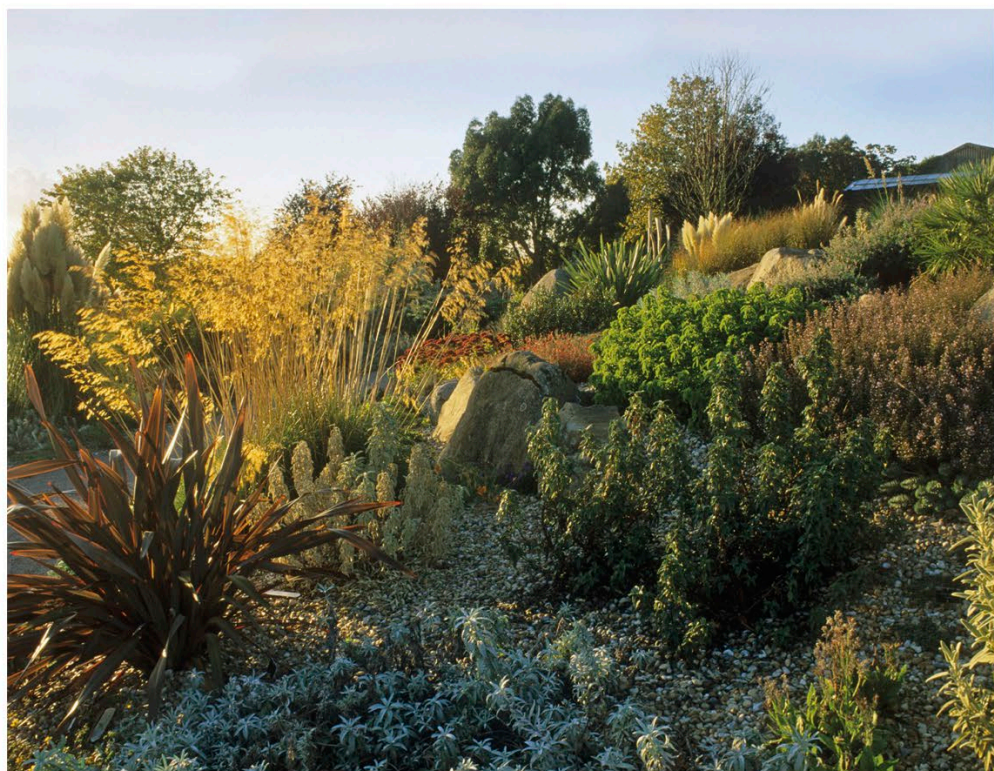
However, the most attainable garden style has an informal structure and relaxed, Mediterranean atmosphere. Gravel is the main hard landscaping material, and is used between areas of planting and to create pathways. Plants native to this region of Europe often have silvery, sage gray-green or blue-tinted foliage, which reflects the strong summer sun. Olive trees, citrus fruits, figs, vines, santolinas, and artemisias, as well as herbs like thyme, sage, lavender, and rosemary, are popular planting choices.

Another informal approach, often seen in urban areas, is to create a courtyard with walls that have been painted white, warm terracotta, or bold blues or pinks. Mosaic-tiled walls, cobbled floors and terra-cotta pots planted with bright pelargoniums or white *Convolvulus cneorum* complete the Mediterranean theme. If you live in a cooler climate, a sun-drenched courtyard will also provide some shelter for tender plants. Hot, south-facing gardens call for a shady arbor or pergola festooned with flowering climbers, such as bougainvilleas or jasmine, to create a comfortable area for alfresco dining or relaxation.



ABOVE Cool Mediterranean courtyard

A Mediterranean courtyard, with gleaming white walls and floor that help reflect the heat of the sun, is perfect for growing sun-loving agapanthus.

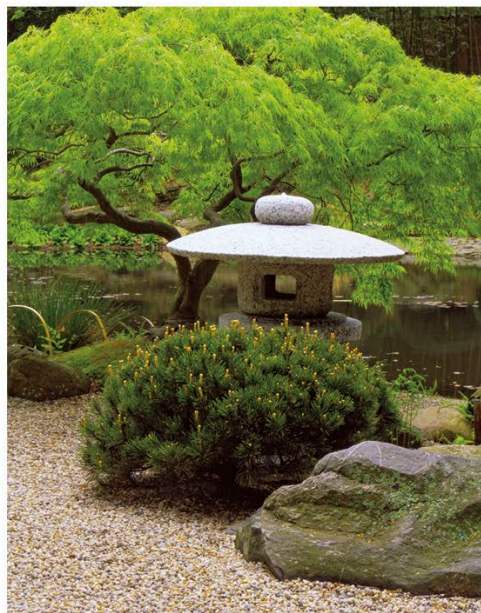


ABOVE Mediterranean planting

Drought-tolerant plants, including spiky phormiums, rock roses, and artemisias, thrive in the gravel of a Mediterranean-style garden on a hot, sunny hillside.

Desert gardens

Dramatic, chic, and starkly beautiful, desert gardens have become very fashionable in hot, frost-free locations with low rainfall. Pale-colored walls, gravel, rocks, boulders, and driftwood are features, together with tough, drought-tolerant plants like cacti and succulents, such as agaves, aloes, and yuccas, which do not need extra irrigation in these hostile environments. In the right place, a desert garden is very eco-friendly, as it focuses on native plants that thrive with little water.



ABOVE Japanese contemplative space

Natural materials, such as carefully positioned rocks and gravel, plants like acers and pines, and ornamental lanterns are typical features of a Japanese garden.

Japanese gardens

The Japanese garden style is designed to reflect the natural landscape using a limited planting palette to produce quiet, contemplative spaces. The key to creating a successful Japanese garden is to consider how the main elements, such as boulders, gravel, and plants, relate to one another, and how they are connected both symbolically and spiritually to the natural world.

In many instances, traditional Japanese spiritual beliefs are fundamental to the designs. Both the ancient religion of Shinto, and the Buddhist teachings that were introduced later, celebrate nature, and all natural elements are regarded as sacred and worthy of respect. In Zen gardens, key elements are used to create representations of natural landscapes. For example, raked gravel is used to echo flowing water, with stones symbolizing islands, boats, or animals. The gravel is raked daily, a ritual viewed by Buddhists as an important aid to contemplation, and the gardens often include little or no planting, relying on moss and lichens rather than on large, dramatic plants.

The cultivation of beauty as a spiritual activity is also reflected in Japanese tea gardens in which a *roji* (dewy path) is lit by stone lanterns and leads the visitor on a journey past water basins, stone buddhas,